

Starting out

The reproductive system is the body system that differs most between males and females. You need a mother and a father to make a baby. Each produces sex cells—the male sperm and female egg—which join to produce a fertilized egg that eventually becomes a baby. Your reproductive system doesn't start working fully until your teenage years.

FERTILIZATION AND AFTER

When sperm meet an egg, they surround it and try to push their way through its tough, jellylike outer layer. Eventually a single sperm succeeds and loses its tail as it enters the egg. The sperm's head and egg's nucleus join together, creating a store of 46 chromosomes that contain the instructions needed to build a new human being. Now fertilized, the egg cells divide repeatedly, eventually forming a tiny embryo.

WOW!

A man's testes make around 3,000 sperm every second. That's 250 million sperm every day.

MALE SYSTEM

The male sex organs—the two testes and the penis—dangle outside the body. The organs are connected to each other by various tubes and glands. In teenagers and adults, millions of sperm are made in the testes. Sperm are carried along the tubes and released through the penis.

The glands release fluids that activate the sperm.

The penis releases sperm into a female vagina.

The testes produce sperm.

The fertilized egg splits into two cells.

The egg divides again into 16 cells, as it travels along the tube.

The egg is fertilized just after it's released from the ovary.

► **SPERM MEETS EGG** Once a month an egg is released from an ovary. If a sperm meets the egg within 24 hours of its release then fertilization will happen.



LOOK CLOSER: SWIMMING SPERM

With a streamlined shape that allows it to swim easily, each sperm is ideally suited to its job. The lollipop-shaped head contains gene instructions. Its long, thin tail whips from side to side to push the sperm toward its destination—the female egg.

The middle section provides energy required for movement.

The tail helps the sperm move.

The head contains genetic information.